

What Is AI?

Ask your desk at school, “Give me 10 ideas for my next history project.”

Nothing. It’s a desk.

Ask the Desk. Ask AI.



✓ AI is software built to do things that used to take a human brain.

Ask a friend, and they can help you brainstorm. Ask AI, and it can give you a list in seconds.

AI is software built to do things that used to take a human brain. Understand a question. Summarize information. Translate a conversation. Suggest ideas for a history project.

That doesn’t mean it thinks like your friend, or that all 10 ideas will be good. But you now have a tool that can help with tasks that once needed a person.

Different AI systems do different jobs. Let’s look at two kinds you already use.

Two Ways You Already Use AI



Recommendation AI

THE JOB

Choose from what already exists.

HOW IT WORKS

Rank the available options and select the likely best match.

EVERYDAY EXAMPLES

Your next Netflix show, Spotify song, or Maps route.



Generative AI

THE JOB

Make something that didn’t exist.

HOW IT WORKS

Use learned patterns to create a new output from your prompt (the question or instructions you give it).

EVERYDAY EXAMPLES

An email, essay, image, website, song, or video.

✓ AI can recommend. AI can create. This course focuses on generative AI.

Here’s what that difference looks like.

One Picks. One Creates.

THE SCENARIO

You’re in the mood for superheroes.



PICKS

Recommendation AI

Chooses from what already exists

THE JOB

Find a superhero movie you might enjoy.

WHAT YOU GET

Captain America: Civil War

A movie selected from an existing catalog based on your interests.

It picked a movie that already exists.



CREATES

Generative AI

Creates something new from your request

THE JOB

Write a scene about two superhero teammates who disagree.

WHAT YOU GET

“We save the bridge,” Maya said. “The hospital loses power in three minutes,” Leo replied. “We can’t do both.”

It generated a scene from your request.

✓ One helps you find something to watch. The other helps you create a story of your own.

Two kinds. One picks, one creates.

This course is about the one that creates.